

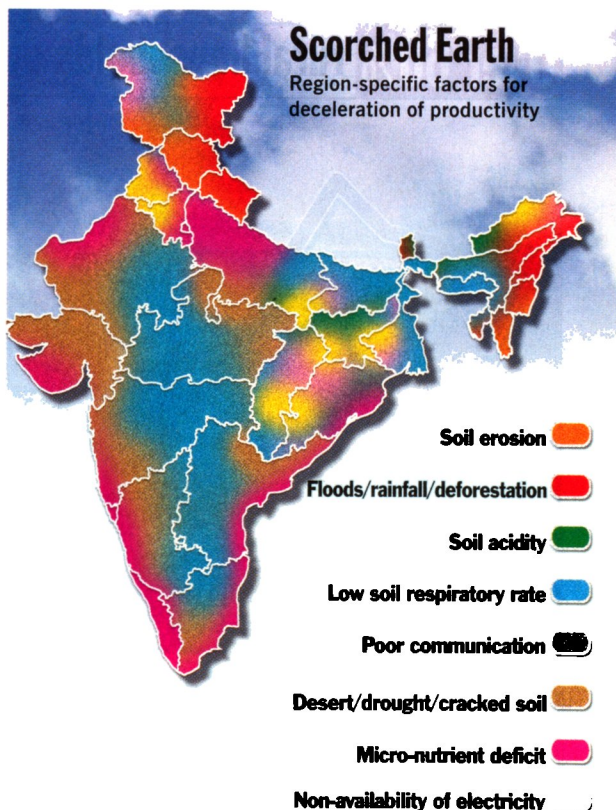
FIELD TRIP: The farmer is the worst hit

AT LAND'S END

UTTAM KHETI, MADDHAM BEOPAR, BHATT CHAKRI (Farming is the best occupation, business is second best and working for someone else is the worst), goes an age-old saying in Punjab. But

Sital Singh, 73-old-farmer from Umedpur village in Ludhiana district, feels it no more holds good as farming has become a losing proposition. The deep creases on his weather-scarred face reflect his state of distress. "Agriculture is now just another name for the struggle for survival," he says with an earthy flourish. Sital owns five acres of land and cultivates 10 more acres of rented land. Until seven years ago, his wheat yield was up to 25 quintal an acre. But it has dipped to 16 quintals over the years. "Everything is going up except my income," he says, referring to the escalating cost of fertilisers, diesel, seed and land lease rates. "Land is behaving like a drug addict. It's demanding more but delivering less and less," he observes.

To boost agricultural production, one of the major factors is availability of land. But as Sital and millions of Indian farmers are realising with growing despair, it is a finite resource. There are just 120 million hectare available for foodgrain production in the country—a figure that has not increased for over two decades now and has in fact begun to



of their current profession.

Source for all graphics: Government of India statistics